

Against a mandated 90 sittings of the state Assembly every year, there were a meagre 13 sessions in 2009 and just 14 so far this year. With neither the ruling party nor the Opposition caring to debate in the House, budgets worth thousands of crores are being passed unchallenged and in a matter of minutes. In February, the supplementary budget demand of Rs 2,522 crore was passed without any discussion.

With the Leader of the House absent, ministers are taking their own decisions, and that too without consulting her. This may lead to them bearing the brunt of the chief minister's wrath later. Singh says, "When I raised a question regarding the release of some prisoners on grounds of mercy, the minister concerned failed to take a decision. This is resulting in overcrowding of jails and overstay of undertrials." During former chief minister Mulayam Singh Yadav's regime, the Panchayati Raj (Amendment) Bill was passed without any discussion. "It is ridiculous to see MLAs raising trivial issues like lack of sanitation in their rooms or not having proper interiors," says Singh, adding, "Political parties are to be blamed for the unabated decline in the standards of the Assembly." Congress MLA Anugrah Narain Singh says, "In the absence of proper discussion and debate, bills are often passed in their draft form."

Ashutosh Mishra, reader in political science at the Lucknow University, says, "There is a parliamentary tradition of no taxation without legislation in countries, including India, Britain and the US. This means that not a single penny is spent by the government without discussion and approval in Parliament". In Uttar Pradesh, however, crores are being passed in the guise of supplementary budgets in a brazen hijacking of the system by the ruling party, whether it is the BSP, SP or BJP.

Mayawati alone is not to be blamed. It was the same during the time of the SP's Mulayam or even BJP's Rajnath Singh. Unfortunately, this dangerous trend will eventually lead



CHIEF MINISTER MAYAWATI HAS ATTENDED the Assembly five times and that too only on important occasions.

Loss of the Land

The state Assembly has to meet at least 90 times in a year according to constitutional provisions.

Years	Sittings
2001	36
2002	32
2003	15
2004	28
2006	37
2007	32
2009	13
2010	14*

It was only in 1962 that the House had more than 90 sittings. It met 103 times.

**Till May-end*

Source: Uttar Pradesh Assembly Records

to the weakening of the legislature, allowing the bureaucracy to dominate the system. This is happening at a time when the MLAs get handsome allowances along with various funds that includes Rs 1.25 crore annually as *Vidhayak Nidhi* (MLA Development Fund). They get Rs 50,000 per month as salary and perks, an allowance of Rs 250 per day for public work and Rs 500 for attending an official meeting. They also get a monthly fuel allowance of Rs 8,000, and coupons worth Rs 2 lakh for rail and air travel, car and housing loans worth Rs 2 lakh annually.

Another reason for the decline in the number of sittings may be fear. In 1997, a fight between members of the Treasury benches and Opposition leaders had sent a number of bleeding MLAs to hospital. Reacting to Mayawati's conspicuous absence in the Assembly, former speaker Kesharinath Tripathi says: "It reflects her I-don't-care attitude". He adds that Mayawati hardly cares for any democratic institution and disregarding the Assembly an example. He is right if one analyses the way she has been cocking a snook at Prime Minister Manmohan Singh's invitation to attend the Planning Commission meetings. She has always spurned the invitation, preferring to stay home. Even when the BSP government called a meeting of industrialists in Mumbai, she sat back in Lucknow and let her bureaucrats handle it. The meeting failed miserably. In another instance, when US Ambassador Timothy J. Roemer sought an appointment with her in Lucknow on March 16, the chief minister's office rejected it.

The Uttar Pradesh Assembly with a staff of over 600 is headed by state Principal Secretary Pradeep Dubey. Each year Rs 55 crore is spent on its maintenance with a part of it going to the upkeep of its vast library, which used to be a favourite haunt of MLAs in the past. Reading for pleasure may not be a favoured pastime of Mayawati and her MLAs but making a caricature of the Assembly certainly seems to be one .